



Cyber-Palaeontology

There is something known as Cyber-palaeontology and it surrounds cyberattacks. Check it out. <https://digit.in/mar20-45>



Longest dinosaur name

The longest dinosaur name as of date is *Micropachycephalosaurus* which consists of 23 letters. <https://digit.in/mar20-46>



FROM THE VERY BEGINNING OF PALAEOLOGY

With a history that spans all of mankind's existence, the origins of palaeontology are hard to pinpoint

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oss Geller from the popular TV show *F.R.I.E.N.D.S.* and movies like *Jurassic Park* made the term 'palaeontologist' a household term in English-speaking households, but is palaeontology limited to studies of dinosaurs? No, because it is the scientific study of *all* prehistoric life.

AT THE VERY BEGINNING...

Humankind has been interested in fossils for as long as one can remember. There have been Neanderthal graves that have been found with fossils in them. The placement of these fossils suggest that they were either used for religious or decorative purposes. In even earlier civilizations, fossils were used as jewellery, but their worth and significance as a scientific tool was not fully understood.

BEFORE THE 1600s

While the term 'palaeontology' was officially coined only in 1822 by the famed French zoologist, Henri Marie Ducrotoy, there were significant documented observations made way before his time. It was as early as the sixth century BCE that Xenophanes of Colophon (Greek philosopher, 570 – 480 BCE) theorised that fossil shells were remains that had survived from prehistoric shellfish. He used this theory to conclude what was dry land during his time had once been under the sea.



Xenophanes of Colophon was and Leonardo Da Vinci were among the first few to conclude that shells were fossilised remains of shellfish.

Two thousand years later, in one of his unpublished notebooks, Leonardo Da Vinci (1452 – 1519) came to a similar conclusion. In both cases, the fossilised shells closely resembled living species of shellfish, making it easier for both Xenophanes and Da Vinci to classify them.

Da Vinci was responsible for drawing a line of continuity between what would later be known as the two main branches of palaeontology – body fossil palaeontology (finding fossilised shells, bones, etc) and ichnology (better known as trace fossils). Trace fossils can be described as fossilised products of an organism's interactions with its environment – burrows, borings, teeth marks, foot prints, etc.

THE 1600s

Things began to change during the Age of Reason. It was around the mid 1600s that there were first mentions of 'Petrify'd wood and Petrify'd bodies'. This term was first noticed in *Micrographia*, which was an illustrated collection of observations by Robert Hooke. He differentiated petrified wood and normal wood by saying that the former is just wood that is soaked with "water impregnated with stony and earthy particles". According to Hooke, fossils were evidence of the history of life on Earth. In his book, he wrote that if finding coins, medals, and other monuments of historical figures meant that these famous people had once existed, then the same validation should be given to petrified flora and fauna.

Around the same time that Hooke was making these observations, Nicholas Steno (geologist) wrote a paper on a shark head that he had dissected. Until that point most people believed that glossopetrae or "tongue stones" were petrified tongues of dragons. By concluding that these fossils may have been shark teeth, he started changing the dialogue on fossils. There were objections, of course, but Steno began studying rock strata to prove himself right. In 1669, he published a paper about how one solid could be naturally enclosed in another solid in which he clearly differentiated fossils and crystals.